

very few people enjoy. But when you're doing it to get more of what you really love, in a way that works for you, then you'll find the results are very fun."

How we came to this response is the work we intend to show you throughout this book.

Spending Is What We Do, Not Who We Are

When I (Jen) read Amber's email for the first time, I felt like I could've written it. Seven years ago, I couldn't stick to a budget, no matter how high my debt got or how important I knew it was. I'd make a budget that made sense mathematically, but I'd always overspend in one category or another (or all of them). I truly wanted to do better financially, but when it came to spending, I could tell myself no sometimes but not most of the time. And I figured if I couldn't do it right, I might as well stop doing it altogether. Because all budgeting was doing for me was making me feel guilty and childish every time I pulled out my credit card. So, most of the time I'd ignore my savings account and my ever-increasing student loan debt.

Ignoring my financial situation was helpful in that I avoided the crushing weight of anxiety that came with caring. But it was replaced by an underlying anxiety of not knowing what was truly going on. I didn't know how to happily deprive myself, and if wanting to have fun was financially irresponsible, then I'd take it any day over living under a rock. I felt incapable of doing the thing the experts were telling me I should be able to do. I'd spend money, feel guilty, internalize that guilt, and conclude, I'm a "spender." That's what I do, other people are good at saving, I'm good at spending. I don't need to be wealthy. But even when I tried ignoring my debt and tried not to feel guilty about my spending, there was still a twinge of guilt with every purchase I made because I knew I'd never have the feeling of being financially secure.

After several years of this, I met my husband, and in the span of two years we paid off \$78,000 of debt and bought a home. I learned that I could stop spending money pretty much altogether. I threw myself into it and took an extreme approach. We didn't eat out, take trips, or buy furniture for the house that was double the size of our apartment. We were living off one salary and putting the entire other salary toward debt. When we decided to